

the firm I'd been cheating on. This feeling quickly gave way to my feeling like an idiot for calling Ms. Garrett under any circumstances. It had not helped our relationship—at least from my side—that Angstrom had gone the wrong way in the greatest bull market in history.

Then there was the dilemma of selling or not selling. Any stock you hold might eventually go up, but the act of selling at a loss forces you to admit you made a mistake. At this painful moment of truth, I thought of the Great Gabelli, and the slim chance that the smart money, i.e., his and mine, should continue to hold on.

I hesitate to mention it, but I also worried that selling the Angstrom might hurt Ms. Garrett's feelings. Then I reminded myself of something I'll leave with you as Useful Tip Number 14:

Don't continue losing money just to keep your broker happy

By the time I'd finished dialing the number, I'd nearly talked myself out of what had to be done. Just as Ms. Garrett picked up, I reached a sensible compromise with my conflicting emotions: sell half.

"What's the Angstrom worth?" I asked.

"I^{13/16}."

"Is there anything else an analyst would recommend? I'd like to work with an analyst."

"Funny you mention it. Just a while ago, I was listening to an analyst over the morning call on our squawk box. Gillette. Nancy Hall says it's a buy. She's touting the domestic story."

(The "squawk box" is a loudspeaker in each field office that's connected to the home office. In the "morning call," the analysts broadcast their latest recommendations to thousands of local brokers at once. That's how many brokers get the new ideas they pass along to you.)

"Who's Nancy Hall?"

"Our cosmetics analyst in New York."

I got so excited at this chance to get in early on an analyst's best